



CASE STUDY

Marshall University Assesses New Programs with Hanover's Expertise

Marshall University partnered with Hanover Research to refine its new academic program process, paving the way for successful program launches.



THE INSTITUTION

Marshall University

INSTITUTION TYPE

Public undergraduate and graduate university

LOCATION

Huntington, West Virginia

THE CHALLENGE

Establish a data-driven process for evaluating new academic programs

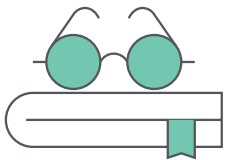
HANOVER SOLUTION

Academic Program Assessments

Marshall University in Huntington, West Virginia, describes itself as a growth-oriented midsize institution where opportunity meets value. With over 120 academic programs, Marshall continues to expand its offerings to meet growing student and employer demand. Dr. Avinandan “Avi” Mukherjee, Provost and Senior Vice President for Academic Affairs, sought to streamline and standardize the new program assessment process to ensure all program launch decisions are made with the greatest opportunity for success.

THE CHALLENGE: REFRESH THE NEW ACADEMIC PROGRAM ASSESSMENT PROCESS

Marshall needed an efficient, centralized method to collect data and reveal insights on student demand, labor market demand, and market saturation for all new academic program proposals. Mukherjee and other leaders previously relied on a complicated reporting process, which lacked efficiency and quantifiable measurements of market demand.



12

The number of new programs approved at Marshall based on Hanover's recommendations



83

The number of students enrolled in five Hanover-approved programs as of spring 2024

“Our previous process for evaluating academic program proposals was very long and involved many steps across shared governance units. We did not consistently measure demand in an objective, quantifiable way or look at competition in a clear-cut manner. I knew we needed a better way to consider new programs, so I made it a requirement that every program submission completes a Hanover study. Now everyone knows this is a standard part of the process and it's much more systematized.”

—Dr. Avinandan “Avi” Mukherjee,
Provost and Senior Vice President for Academic Affairs

Explore trending academic programs and job opportunities in the U.S. with our resource, **Top 10 Degrees on the Rise in 2024**.



THE SOLUTION: DEVELOP AN EFFICIENT STANDARD OF ACADEMIC PROGRAM REVIEW

In collaboration with Mukherjee and Vice President for Institutional Research Brian Morgan, Hanover Research introduced a new step in the academic program proposal process for evaluating the viability of a potential program and used it to conduct over 20 assessments of undergraduate and graduate proposals for the university.

With this successful model in place, Mukherjee instituted the assessment process as a standard requirement for all potential programs. The report is reviewed by key campus stakeholders, including the Faculty Senate, Graduate Council, Academic Planning Committee, and University Curriculum Committee before a new program proposal can receive final approval by Marshall's Board of Governors.

The new assessment process includes questions such as:

What is the market demand for the program?

- What does student demand look like for the program in the state, region, and nation?
- How likely will graduates of the program find employment? What will their jobs look like?
- What industry trends are likely to impact demand?
- What is the optimal tuition price point for a new program?

What is the competitive landscape for the program?

- What program features do similar programs include (such as modalities, credit hours, concentrations, course offerings, and programmatic accreditation)?
- How can Marshall compete and differentiate its program from peer institutions?

“Hanover’s approach was extremely helpful in assessing the viability of two new engineering programs. When we reviewed the market data, we realized the demand for a chemical engineering master’s just wasn’t there, so we dropped it and pursued the approval process for the PhD in Engineering instead. We recently launched the program and enrollment is already looking good.”

—Dr. Avinandan “Avi” Mukherjee,
Provost and Senior Vice President for Academic Affairs

THE OUTCOME : LAUNCHING PROGRAMS BASED ON STUDENT AND EMPLOYER DEMAND

To date, Marshall has successfully launched eight programs based on Hanover’s assessment report recommendations, with an additional four programs scheduled for future launch. This includes the Doctor of Business Administration (DBA) program, which launched in 2021, more than doubling in size by spring 2024. The DBA program exemplifies success in both revenue and visibility, with the program’s launch positively impacting Marshall’s R2 Carnegie Classification (Doctoral Universities – High research activity).

Hanover’s findings have helped Marshall identify viable programs, while avoiding those that fail to meet market demand. For example, the College of Engineering identified two potential programs — a Master of Science in Chemical Engineering and a PhD in Engineering — however, Hanover’s assessment allowed Marshall’s leaders to concentrate their efforts on developing the PhD program, which displayed stronger indicators of future success.

Hanover’s new academic program assessments continue to demonstrate measurable institutional impacts, informing current operations, fiscal plans, and strategic planning. Looking forward, Marshall will continue to require Hanover’s assessment process for all new program proposals. Additionally, Marshall will explore how Hanover may assist with its review processes for existing academic programs and assessments of other campus-wide initiatives.



\$250,000+

The anticipated yearly tuition revenue for the BFA in Filmmaking program launching in 2024–25



100%

The percentage growth in enrollment in the Doctor of Business Administration program between fall 2021 and 2023 (from 16 students to 33)

Learn how to conduct a transparent, data-driven process to help your institution make the best programmatic investments with our **Step-by-Step Guide to Comprehensive Academic Portfolio Review**.

